Epilogue

The Emperor’s Afterlife

WHEN ASHOKA’S COMMUNICATIONS TO HIS PEOPLE ceased, his historical persona, for all practical purposes, ceased as well; and some years later, around 232 BCE, he passed away. Yet in the centuries after his death his memory lived on, and in ways that go well beyond the events and drama of his life. His afterlife is in fact a configuration of diverse and fascinating threads made up of material relics and writings stretching across more than two millennia. In ancient and medieval India Ashoka was remembered in legendary accounts, court chronicles, travel tales, and epigraphs. To this one may add what more contemporary times have contributed to that memorialization: he has figured in film and fiction, on public architecture, in the lives and work of India’s national heroes, and through Indian national symbols. The desire to deploy remembrances and memorializations of this emperor is practically irresistible among Indians. A consequence of this has been that in reconstructions of the life and times of Ashoka the line which divides history and memory is frequently blurred.

In attempting to recover the historical Ashoka I have tried to separate out these threads, highlighting in the early chapters the various possibilities and challenges of using later legends and chronicles which evoke him. Even as I have dipped into those accounts to reconstruct large parts of his life and times—for which there is nothing remotely contemporary—the core of my narrative revolves around Ashoka’s own voice and the archaeological histories of the landscapes where it resonated. Now, I return to recall Ashoka’s afterlife, or some of the meanderings that have not found a place in my narrative, through which the memory of this extraordinary emperor